Growing up in Queenstown, I've always assumed that real tech experience was something that was only possible in big cities or overseas. Most of mine was limited to my Digital Technologies class and volunteering with Local groups like WYT.

Joining Skyline changed that completely. We were trusted with a project that actually mattered to the business and given tools students rarely get access to.

Alongside Ollie, Alicia, and Oscar, our task was to build an AI sentiment platform from scratch that analyses live customer data.

Skyline had previously been paying a third party provider, so our objective was to build a custom internalised version tailored to their operational needs.

Skyline provided the opportunity to accelerate our technical skills, and in return, we delivered a solution that created real commercial value for the business.

We played to our strengths: Ollie and I focused on the front-end and API connections, while Alicia and Oscar managed the database and AI agents.

It was a steep learning curve, but the environment was incredibly supportive. IT, cybersecurity, financial analysts, and web teams gave us proper system access, while Mike's mentorship kept us grounded in what the business actually required.

The most defining moment for me was presenting our working platform to Skyline's executive team including the CEO, GMs, and the heads of Finance and IT. Standing in front of senior leadership was certainly out of my comfort zone, but delivering a working solution to a business problem gave me a level of confidence I couldn't have built anywhere else.

In just a few weeks, this hands-on experience taught me more than five years in a classroom ever could. It proved that regional students don't have to leave home to create an impact.

It is precisely the reason I'm headed to Auckland to study Computer Science and Finance next year, because now I see how technology and business intersect in practice. And more importantly, having this pathway makes me want to bring those skills back home after I graduate.

To the business leaders in the room: when you invest in local talent, you're not just offering a job - you're giving a student the discipline and belief to build a real career.
Nga Mihi Nui.